Guess What? I Almost Kissed My Father Good Night

By Robert Cormier

I've got to get to the bottom of it all somehow any maybe this is the best way. It's about my father. I found out recently that my father is actually forty-five years old, and he has the kind of terrible job that fathers have -- an office manager for a computer equipment concern. He reads a couple of newspapers every day and never misses the seven o'clock news on television.

He's five ten, weighs 160 pounds, has a tendency toward high blood pressure, likes his steak medium rare and has a habit of saying that "tonight, by God, I'm going to stay up and watch Johnny Carson," but always gropes his way to bed after the eleven o'clock news, which he watches only to learn the next day's weather forecast.

I'm Mike, almost sixteen and a sophomore in high school.

4NG Fanatics

INTRODUCTION

OK . . . I'll admit it . . . I never thought about my parents, especially my father, being "real" people. But the story I want to share with you made me stop and think. A lot. And I've come to the conclusion that people–all people–are fallible. Parents don't have life completely figured out; sometimes they are winging it, just like their kids. And when I realized this, I realized I had to spend some quality time with my dad – as a "real" person.

Guess What? I Almost Kissed My Father Good Night by Robert Cormier

Now that you have gotten the basic details, I'll tell you about that day last month. I was barrel[ing] through Bryant Park, a shortcut, the turf spring-soft and spongy under my feet and the weeping willows hazy with blossom. Suddenly I screeched to a halt, like Bugs Bunny in one of those crazy television cartoons. There he is: my father. Sitting on the park bench. Gazing out over a small pond. My father was deep in thought, like a statue in a museum. I looked at my watch. Two-thirty in the afternoon, for crying out loud. What was he doing there at this time of day? I was about to approach him but hesitated, held back

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

for some reason—I don't know why. Although he looked perfectly normal, I felt as though I had somehow caught him naked, had trespassed on forbidden territory. I drew back, studying him as if he were a sudden stranger. I saw the familiar thinning short hair, the white of his scalp showing through. The way the flesh in his neck has begun to pucker like turkey skin. Now, he sighed. I saw his shoulders heave, and the rest of his body shudder like the chain reaction of freight cars. He lifted his face to the sun, eyes closed. I tiptoed away.

At dinner that evening, I'm uncommunicative, thinking of all the science homework waiting in my room. I have this truly tremendous appetite and I eat too fast, like my mother says. But that evening I stopped eating altogether when my mother asked my father about his day at the office.

"Routine," he said. I thought of the scene in the park. "Didn't even have time for a coffee break," he said, reaching for more potatoes.

4N6 Fanatics

I almost choked on the roast beef. He lied: my father actually lied. I sat there, terrified, caught in some kind of terrible no-man's-land. It was as if the lie itself had thrust me into panic. I was bothered by his motive. I mean—why did he have to pretend that he *wasn't* in the park that afternoon? And the first question came back to haunt me worse than before—what was he doing there, anyway, in the first place?

I found myself studying him across the table, scrutinizing him with the eyes of a stranger. But it didn't work. He was simply my father. Looking exactly as he always did. He was his usual dull unruffled self, getting ready to take his evening nap prior to the television news. Stifling a yawn after desert. Forget it, I told myself. There's a simple explanation for everything.

Let's skip some time now until the night of the telephone call. Father never answers the phone. He lets it ring nine or ten or eleven times and merely keeps on reading the paper and watching television because he claims—and he's right—that most of the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

phone calls are for me. Anyway, a few nights after that happening at the park, the phone rang about ten-thirty and I barreled out of my room because he and my mother get positively explosive about calls after nine o'clock on school nights.

When I lifted the receiver, I found that my father had already picked up the downstairs extension. There was a pause and then he said: "I've got it, Mike."

"Yes, sir," I said. And hung up.

I stood there in the upstairs hallway, not breathing. His voice was a murmur and even at that distance I detected some kind of intimacy. I returned to my room and I remembered that my mother was out for the evening, a meeting of the Ladies' Auxiliary. Who had called him on the telephone at that hour of the night? And why had he answered the call in record time? Was it the same person he'd been waiting for in Bryant's Park? Don't be ridiculous, Mike, I told myself

4NG Fanatics

Later, I went downstairs and my father was slumped in his chair, newspaper like a fragile tent covering his face. His snores capsized the tent and it slid to the floor. He needed a shave, his beard like small slivers of ice. His feet were fragile, something I had never noticed before; they were mackerel white, half in and half out of his slippers. He wasn't mysterious: he was my father. And he snored with his mouth open.

Detective work -- detective work sent me investigating my father's desk the next day. No one was at home. The desk was unlocked. I opened the drawers and checked some diary like type notebooks. Nothing but business stuff. Dull. But a bottom drawer revealed the kind of box that contains correspondence paper and envelopes. Inside, I found envelopes of different shapes and sizes and colors. Father's Day cards he had saved through the years. I found one with a scrawled "Mikey" painstakingly written when I was four or five probably.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

"Looking for something?" His shadow fell across the desk. I mumbled something, letting irritation show in my voice. I have found that you can fake adults out by muttering and grumbling as if you're using some foreign language that they couldn't possibly understand. And they feel intimidated or confused. Anyway, they decide not to challenge you or make an issue of it. That's what happened at that moment. There I was snooping in my father's desk and because I muttered unintelligibly when he interrupted me, *he* looked embarrassed while I stalked from the room as if I were the injured party.

[The next week, out of a deep sleep,] suddenly I awoke. My watch said one-twenty . . . in the morning. I went downstairs for a glass of orange juice. A light spilled from the den. He's there: my father. Slumped in his chair. Like death. And I almost dropped dead myself. But his lips flutter and he produces an enormous snore. One arm dangles to the floor, limp as a draped towel. His fingers are almost touching a book that had evidently fallen from his

4NG Fanatics

hand. I pick it up. Poetry. A poet I never heard of. Kenneth Fearing. In the front of the book there's an inscription. Delicate handwriting, faded lavender ink. "To Jimmy, I'll never forget you. Muriel." Jimmy? My father's name is James and my mother and his friends call him Jim. But Jimmy? I notice a date at the bottom of the page, meticulously recorded in that same fragile handwriting—November 2, 1942—when he was young enough to be called Jimmy. By some girl whose name was Muriel, who gave him a book of poems. He stirs, grunting, clearing his throat, his hand like a big white spider searching the floor for the book. I replace the book on the floor and glide out of the room and back upstairs.

The following day, I [again] spotted my father. He was crossing the street, dodging traffic. I checked my watch: two-fifty-five. He paused in front of the Monument Public Library and disappeared inside. My father—visiting the library? He didn't even have a library card, for crying out loud. As I stood here, I saw Laura Kincaid drive up in her new LeMans.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

A quiet, dark green LeMans. Class. "If I had to describe Laura Kincaid in one word, it would have to be 'class'" I'd heard my father say once. She is blond, her hair color of lemonade as it's being poured on a hot day. I stood there, paralyzed —trying to figure out why she was at this moment walking across the street, heading for the library, her hair a lemon halo in the sun, her nylons flashing as she hurried. Was she on her way to a rendezvous? Stop it, you nut, I told myself, even as I made my way to the side entrance.

And then I saw them. Together. My father wasn't looking at the books or the shelves or the walls or the ceilings or the floor or anything. He was looking at her. Then, they laughed. It was like a silent movie. I mean—I saw their eyes light up and their lips moving but didn't hear anything. My father shook his head, slowly, a smile lingering tenderly on his face. His hand reached up and touched her shoulder. They laughed again She indicated the books in her arms. He nodded, an eagerness in his manner. He didn't look

4NG Fanatics

as if he had ever snored in his life or taken a nap after dinner.

Pressed against the metal bookshelf, I felt conspicuous, vulnerable, as if they would suddenly whirl and see me, and point accusing fingers. But nothing like that happened. She finally left, simply walked away, the books still in her arm. My father watched her go, his face in shadow, until she disappeared from view. I watched him for a minute or two as he stood there looking down, his eyes tracing the path of her departure as if she were still visible. I studied his face: was this my father? And then, this terrible numbness invaded my body, like a Novocain of the spirit, killing all my emotions.

At dinner, the food lay unappetizing on my plate. I had to fake my way through the meal, lifting the fork mechanically.

"Aren't you feeling well, Mike?" my mother asked.

I leaped about five feet off my chair. I hadn't realized how obvious I must have appeared: the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

human eating machine suddenly toying with his food—steak at that, which requires special concentration.

"I met Laura Kincaid at the library today," I heard my father say.

"Was she able to get a copy of the play?" my mother asked.

"Two of them," he said, munching. "I still think *Streetcar Named Desire* is pretty ambitious for you girls to put on."

"The Woman's Auxiliary knows no fear of Tennessee Williams," my mother said in that exaggerated voice she uses when she's kidding around.

"You know, that's funny, Dad," I heard myself saying. "I saw you in the library this afternoon and was wondering what you were doing there."

"Oh? I didn't see you, Mike."

"He was supposed to pick up the play on my library card. But then Laura Kincaid came by…" That was my mother explaining it all, although I barely made out the words.

4NG Fanatics

I won't go into the rest of the scene and I won't say that my appetite suddenly came back and that I devoured the steak. Because I didn't. That was two days ago and I still feel funny about it all. Strange I mean. That first time in the park when he was sitting there. The telephone call. That book of poetry he reads late at night, "To Jimmy, I'll never forget you. Muriel." Laura Kincaid in the library. Not much evidence, really. Especially when I look at him and see how he's my father all right.

Last night, I came downstairs after finishing my homework -- he had just turned off the television set. We stood there in the half-darkness.

"Hey, Dad." I didn't plan to ask him. But it popped out. "I was looking through a book of yours the other day. Poetry by some guy named Fearing or Nearing or something." I couldn't see his face in the half dark. Keeping my voice light, I said: "Who's this Muriel who gave you the book, anyway?"

His laugh was a playful bark. "Boy, that was a long time ago. Muriel Stanton." He closed the kitchen

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

window. "I asked her to go to the Senior Prom but she went with someone else. And so she gave me a gift—of friendship—at graduation. That's a lousy swap, Mike. A book instead of a date with a girl you're crazy about." He smiled ruefully.

You see? Simple explanation for everything. And if I exposed myself as a madman, and asked him about the other stuff, the park and the telephone call, I knew there would be perfectly logical reasons. And yet. I remember that day in the library, when Laura Kincaid walked away from him. I said that I couldn't see his face, not clearly anyway, but I could see a bit of his expression. And it looked familiar but I couldn't pin it down. All kind of crumpled up. Or was that my imagination?

"Mike. Everybody gets the blues now and then. Even fathers are people. Sometimes, I can't sleep and get up and sit in the dark in the middle of the night. And it gets lonesome because you think of…"

"What do you think of, Dad?"

He yawned. "Oh, a lot of things."

4NG Fanatics

That's all. And here I am sitting up in the middle of the night thinking of Muriel Stanton who wouldn't go to the Senior Prom with my father. How he gets lonesome sometimes. And sits up in the night, reading poetry. I think of his anguished face at the library and the afternoon at Bryant Park, and all the mysteries of his life that show he's a person. Human.

Earlier tonight, I saw him in his chair, reading the paper, and I said, "Goodnight, Dad," and he looked up and smiled, but an absent kind of smile, as if he were thinking of something else, long ago and far away. . . and I felt like kissing him goodnight. But didn't, of course. Who kisses his father at sixteen?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert Cormier
Book: 8 Plus 1
ISBN: 978-0440208389
Publisher: Laurel Leaf
Date (Month/Year): March 1991

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY